

Travel Social Media Involvement: A Proposed Measure

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Abstract This study proposes a measure to determine traveller's level of involvement with travel social media websites. Social media involvement is defined as a person's level of interest, emotional attachment or arousal with social media. This measure is important because understanding travellers' level of involvement with social media is paramount, enabling social media marketers to personalize online marketing strategies and predict behaviours (e.g. online travel purchases). Therefore, this research contributes to the development of literature on travel related social media by providing an instrument to measure travellers' involvement with travel related social media. A confirmatory factor analysis conducted with a sample of 1,732 respondents demonstrates that social media involvement can be conceptualized as a formative multidimensional construct, formed by interest in social media, social media consumption, social media creation and perceived playfulness with the use of social media (all for travel related purposes).

Keywords Involvement • Social media • Travel • User generated content

1 Introduction

The Internet has drastically changed the way travellers search for information (Arsal et al. 2008) and is an increasingly popular means to search for travel information (Xiang and Gretzel 2010). With the rapidly developing of the Web 2.0, social media Websites have gained popularity not only in online travellers' search for information (Xiang and Gretzel 2010) but also to post information regarding their trips, through comments, photos or pictures (Parra-López

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et al. 2012). Different statistics evidence the importance of social media in the travel context. Approximately one-fifth of leisure travellers worldwide use social media for travel planning (eMarketer 2013). A study conducted by PhocusWright, one of the leading travel industry research firms, found that 80 % of the respondents read at least six reviews before booking an accommodation (Tnooz 2014). A different study demonstrated that reviews were more important than price when choosing a hotel (Noone and McGuire 2013). The same study found that negative reviews would eliminate a hotel from consideration, regardless of price.

Although there are many studies focusing on traveller's use of social media and its effect on travel planning and travel decisions, research on travellers level of involvement with social media websites is scarce. However, it is important to study traveller's involvement with social media involvement as travellers who are more involved with social media have different characteristics and behaviours. While some travellers seem to have an active behaviour on these social media websites, with high levels of involvement, others are not as active. According to Forrester Research, 75 % of Internet users use social media, but less than half actively participate (Osborn 2009). Gretzel et al. (2007) found important differences between members of Tripadvisor concerning their social media use. For example, those that read travel reviews more frequently than others travel frequently for pleasure and have higher incomes, representing an attractive market for travel marketers. Moreover, travellers that read online reviews more frequently are more likely to be highly influenced by other travellers' reviews (Gretzel et al. 2007). Gretzel et al. (2007) found that, in contrast to those who do not actively write travel reviews, travel review writers are more involved in trip planning than non-writers. They also found that travel review writers are also more likely to see other travellers' reviews as superior to travel provider information and are more influenced by reviews. A Forrester Research report also advises online travel marketers to pay attention to a group of online leisure travellers termed conversationalists, who participate in social media conversation since they have the potential to drive sales (Harteveldt et al. 2010). In conclusion, online travel marketers need to pay attention to travellers more involved with social media, since they are more likely to influence other with their reviews, are also more influenced by reviews wrote by others, are more likely to have higher incomes and are more involved in trip planning.

This study proposes a measure to examine travellers' level of involvement with travel social media websites. In the era of social media, understanding travellers' level of involvement with social media is paramount, enabling social media marketers to personalize online marketing strategies and predict behaviours (e.g. online travel purchases). Moreover, travellers with higher levels of involvement represent an attractive segment for travel marketers.

The remainder of the article is organized as follows. The next section reviews existing literature on use of social media in the travel context and involvement, to provide the basis for the proposed measures. Then, measures are proposed and tested for travel social media involvement. Finally, the last section discusses the usefulness of the travel social media involvement construct and points out future research directions.

2 Literature Review

2.1 *Use of Social Media for Travel*

Travel Social Media websites have facilitated traveller's access to travel information and are therefore a powerful source for travel planning. The most important factor influencing travellers to participate in online travel communities is information acquisition ([Chung and Buhalis 2008a](#)). According to [Gretzel and Yoo \(2008\)](#) travel review readers consider information posted by other travellers to be superior to marketer information. Moreover, their results illustrated that travel reviews played an important role in the trip planning process, by providing ideas, reducing risk and making it easier to imagine what places would be like.

Several studies have confirmed the important role social media have on influencing travel decisions. Indeed, exposure to an online hotel review improves the probability for consumers to consider booking a room in the reviewed hotel ([Vermeulen and Seegers 2009](#)). This conclusion is echoed in a more recent study conducted by [Sparks and Browning \(2011\)](#) which reinforces the persuasive impact that positive reviews have on intentions to book. In a different study, 84 % of travel review users reported that the reviews had a significant influence on their purchase decisions. ([ComScore 2007](#)).

While some individuals actively participate in travel related social media, by posting comments, photos and videos, others do not demonstrate such an active role. [Shao \(2009\)](#) suggests that individuals deal with user generated media in three ways: by consuming, by participating, and by producing. Consuming refers to the individuals who only read, or view but never participate. Participating includes both user-to-user interaction and user-to-content interaction (such as ranking the content, adding to playlists, sharing with others, posting comments, etc.). Producing encompasses creation and publication of one's personal contents such as text, images, audio, and video. Studies show that most individuals are consumers or participators ([Yoo and Gretzel 2011](#)) referred to as lurkers ([Ridings et al. 2006](#)). Producers initiate the life cycle of user generated media, with the purpose of attracting others' attention ([Shao 2009](#)) and, viewed from a social exchange theory perspective, do so in the expectation of receiving benefits through recognition, through influencing the nature of the community, and through knowing they helped another person ([Ridings et al. 2006](#)). [Ridings et al. \(2006\)](#) found that producers reported stronger desires to give and to get information, to exchange social support and to obtain shopping information than lurkers and infrequent posters.

Individuals engage in a particular behaviour if it provides them enjoyment and fun. [Shao \(2009\)](#) argues that people may use user generated media just like traditional media for entertainment purposes such as escaping from problems, relaxing, filling time and seeking emotional release. In the travel context, studies have shown that reading travel reviews added fun to the trip planning process, made travel planning more enjoyable and made travellers feel more excited about travelling ([Gretzel and Yoo 2008](#); [Gretzel et al. 2007](#)). [Chung and Buhalis \(2008b\)](#)

found that users of online travel communities (e.g. Tripadvisor.com, VirtualTourist.com) participated in the online community activities not only for the informational benefits, but also for the hedonic benefits (i.e. “Having fun with contents”, “Entertainment” and “To be amused by members”). Similarly, Wang and Fesenmaier (2004) found that hedonic need were an important predictor for the level of participation in an online travel community. Enjoyment also is driver of travel content generated media creation (Yoo and Gretzel 2011). This empirical evidence demonstrates that individuals use travel social media websites not only for information purposes but also because they consider its use enjoyable. Web 2.0 has made information search more personalized, active and interactive, which contributes to its hedonic value (Gretzel 2012).

2.2 *Social Media Involvement*

Grounded on Rothchild’s (1984) definition of involvement, the current study defines social media involvement as a person’s level of interest, emotional attachment or arousal with social media. The adaption of this definition to explore travellers’ involvement with social media seems appropriate to extend the knowledge of social media use for travel purposes.

Researchers have argued that involvement can be conceived in behavioural terms. For instance, Stone (1984) defined involvement as the time and/or intensity of effort expended in pursuing a particular activity. Engel et al. (1995) also suggested that involvement could be measured by the time spent in product search, the energy spent and the extent of the decision process. However, other measures of involvement have included mental states, such as enjoyment/pleasure (Laurent and Kapferer 1985) and importance/interest (Laurent and Kapferer 1985; Mittal 1989; Zaichkowsky 1985).

This study takes Stone’s (1984) view that involvement is both a mental state and a behavioural process. With this in mind and based on the literature review conducted in the previous section, social media involvement is conceptualized as a multidimensional construct based on individual’s usage of social media (consumption and creation), their level of interest in social media and perceived playfulness with the use of social media, as shown in Table 1.

From a behavioural perspective, an individual that is highly involved with social media will be more engaged with travel related social media. Indicators of such behaviour will be their social media consumption and creation behaviour. On the other hand, individuals engage in a particular behaviour if it provides them enjoyment and fun. It is also expected that individuals using travel related social media and experiencing enjoyment are more absorbed and interested in interacting. In sum, individuals with a high social media involvement have a high interest in travel related social media, are highly active on social media, by searching and posting travel related information and enjoy using social media for travel purposes.

Table 1 Dimensions of social media involvement

Social media involvement dimensions	Definition
Social media consumption	Extent to which individuals use social media for travel related information (for example reading reviews or watching videos)
Creation of social media content	Participation on travel related social media by writing reviews, posting photos and videos
Perceived playfulness	Extent to which using social media website for travel purposes is perceived to be entertaining and fun
Level of interest	Overall interest in travel related social media

3 Methodology

3.1 Measure Development

As described in the previous section, social media involvement was conceptualized as composed by four dimensions: social media consumption, creation of social media content, perceived playfulness and level of interest. Based on this conceptualization and the literature review carried out, 20 indicators capturing the various facets of social media involvement were generated. Some of the items considered were developed for the purposes of this study, while others were based on previous studies, modified to make them relevant to the social media usage context. The items used and their sources are shown in Table 2.

For social media consumption and creation, respondents indicated their level of consumption and creation of social media content with the survey items using a five-point Likert-type scale with responses ranging from 1—“Never” to 5—“Always”. Perceived playfulness was measured with a five point Likert scale where 1—“Strongly Disagree” and 5—“Strongly Agree”. Interest in social media was measured with a five point differential semantic scale.

Social Media Involvement was conceptualized as a formative multidimensional construct composed of four dimensions. Each dimension of social media involvement is a component of the social media involvement construct, which would become incomplete if any of the dimensions were missing.

3.2 Data Collection

To assess the proposed measures for social media involvement, data was collected using an online. Since the study focuses on the use of social media websites, it was not necessary to address the concerns of individuals that do not have access to the Internet. A convenience sampling method was used, by sending e-mail invitations to colleagues, students, personal contacts, professional list-serve groups and other email contacts. Moreover, links to the survey were placed on Facebook, namely on

Table 2 Measures for social media involvement's dimensions

Construct	Indicators	References
Consumption of social media	<i>Before travelling...</i> SMC1—I read hotel reviews from other travellers SMC2—I searched for travel information on social media websites SMC3—I looked at activity/attractions reviews of other travellers SMC4—I read other travellers' experiences and tips <i>While travelling...</i> SMC5—I search for travel information on social media websites (for example, where to eat or things to do)	New measures
Creation of social media content	<i>While travelling...</i> SMCR1—I check in to the location I am at/update my location on social media (for example, on Foursquare, Facebook) <i>After travelling...</i> SMCR2—I write hotel reviews on social media websites. SMCR3—I post photos on social media websites. SMCR4—I write reviews of activities/attractions on social media websites. SMCR5—I put videos on social media websites SMCR6—I write reviews of the place and/or monuments I visited on social media websites.	New measures
Perceived playfulness of social media	PP1—Using social media for travel purposes is enjoyable	Adapted from Lee et al. (2005)
	PP2—Using social media websites for travel purposes is fun PP3—Using social media websites for travel purposes stimulates my curiosity	Adapted from Moon and Kim (2001)
	PP4—I consider the use of social media for travel purposes a big hassle. (R)	Adapted from Verhoef and Langerak (2001)
Interest in social media	Social Media for travel purposes is... ISM1 Unimportant...important ISM2—Unexciting...Exciting ISM3—Doesn't matter to me...Matters to me ISM4—Boring...Interesting ISM5—Useless...Useful	McQuarrie and Munson (1992)

the researchers' wall, but also on professional research groups. Although convenience sampling has the disadvantage of offering no guarantee of a representative and unbiased sample (Gravetter and Forzano 2011), it is the most employed method in social and behavioural sciences (Durrheim and Painter 2008; Gravetter and Forzano 2011) and has the advantage of obtaining a large number of responses.

The questionnaire was available online between July 17th and September 12th of 2012. During this period a total of 1,759 complete responses were obtained of which 1,732 were considered valid.

3.3 Respondent's Profile

Respondents in this study were from 51 countries, with a prominence of responses from European residents, specifically Portuguese residents. This was expected, given that the researchers reside in Portugal and have more available contacts from people residing in this country. The age group with the most significant number of responses was the age group 18–29, with 34.6 % of the total of responses, while only approximately 13 % are aged over 50. In terms of gender, there is a slight skew towards a higher proportion of female participants (61.5 %). The sample seems to be composed by highly educated individuals, with approximately 88 % of the respondents holding at least a college degree, against only 11.6 % who have only completed the 12th grade or less. Other studies addressing the use of social media for travel purposes have also revealed similar profiles (e.g. Gretzel and Yoo 2008).

3.4 Instrument Validation

The reliability and validity of the measures were tested with a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) using SmartPLS 2.0 (Ringle et al. 2005). This approach is considered to be more reliable and valid than other approaches (Afthanorhan 2013). Moreover, PLS-SEM readily incorporates both reflective and formative measures (Hair et al. 2013).

As can be observed in Table 3, the data indicates that the measures are robust in terms of their reliability, since all indicator loadings are higher than 0.7 and are significant at the 0.001 level, indicating that each measure is accounting for 50 % or more of the variance of the underlying construct (Chin 1998). Moreover, all Cronbach's alpha are higher than 0.9, way above the minimum threshold of 0.6, demonstrating that each constructs' indicators have the same meaning. Furthermore, the composite reliabilities exceed the recommended threshold value of 0.70 (Bagozzi and Yi 1988).

Construct validity was assessed by both convergent validity, which detects if the indicators for a construct are more correlated with one another than with indicators of another construct, and discriminant validity, which determines if a construct is truly distinct from other constructs both in terms of how much it correlates with other constructs and how distinctly indicators represent only this single construct (Hair et al. 2010).

Table 3 Reliability measures

Construct	Indicators	Indicator loadings	t-statistic	Composite reliability	Cronbach's alfa
Social media consumption	SMC1	0.90	148.91***	0.95	0.94
	SMC2	0.90	152.63***		
	SMC3	0.95	301.21***		
	SMC4	0.95	297.25***		
	SMC5	0.77	68.70***		
Social media Creation	SMCR1	0.72	46.04***	0.93	0.90
	SMCR2	0.75	57.15***		
	SMCR3	0.86	118.23***		
	SMCR4	0.92	225.28***		
	SMCR5	0.77	57.81***		
	SMCR6	0.90	158.36***		
Perceived playfulness of social media	PP1	0.95	321.16***	0.95	0.93
	PP2	0.95	288.96***		
	PP3	0.93	223.21***		
	PP4	0.80	54.07***		
Interest in social media	ISM1	0.84	93.34***	0.94	0.92
	ISM2	0.88	111.45***		
	ISM3	0.89	140.94***		
	ISM4	0.89	123.64***		
	ISM5	0.87	108.78***		

*** Significant at the 0.001 level based on 5,000 bootstrap samples

To assess convergent validity, Fornell and Larcker (1981) suggest using the average variance extracted (AVE). The results, presented in Table 4, support convergent validity, since they all exceed 0.50.

For discriminant validity the two measures that are typically used are the Fornell-Larcker criterion and the cross loadings. The first test assesses if a construct is more strongly related to its own measures than with any other construct by examining the overlap in variance by comparing the AVE of each construct with the squared correlations among constructs (Chin 2010). Table 5 shows the correlations between constructs. The diagonal elements are the square roots of the AVEs that exceed all corresponding off diagonal elements. Therefore, each construct shares more variance with its own block of indicators than with another latent variable representing a different block of indicators, supporting the adequate discriminant validity of the scales.

Discriminant validity was further assessed by extracting the factor and cross loadings of all indicators to their respective constructs. Not only should each indicator be strongly related to the construct it attempts to reflect, but should also not have a stronger connection with another construct (Chin 2010). The results, presented in Table 6, indicate that all indicators loaded on their respective construct more highly than on any other, confirming that the constructs are distinct.

Table 4 Average variance extracted (AVE)

Construct	AVE
Social media consumption	0.80
Social media creation	0.68
Perceived playfulness in social media	0.82
Interest in social media	0.76

Table 5 Discriminant validity of the constructs—correlations between constructs

	Interest in SM	PP of SM	SM consumption	SM creation
Interest in SM	0.87			
PP of SM	0.54	0.91		
SM consumption	0.41	0.78	0.89	
SM creation	0.44	0.60	0.56	0.82

PP Perceived playfulness, *SM* Social media

Table 6 Factor loadings (bolded) and cross loadings

	Interest in SM	PP in SM	Social media consumption	Social media creation
ISM1	0.84	0.48	0.38	0.38
ISM2	0.88	0.47	0.34	0.38
ISM3	0.88	0.49	0.38	0.43
ISM4	0.89	0.48	0.34	0.37
ISM5	0.86	0.43	0.35	0.32
PP1	0.52	0.95	0.76	0.60
PP2	0.53	0.95	0.73	0.60
PP3	0.54	0.93	0.72	0.56
PP4	0.35	0.80	0.61	0.41
SMC1	0.31	0.70	0.90	0.43
SMC2	0.42	0.71	0.90	0.53
SMC3	0.37	0.72	0.95	0.50
SMC4	0.36	0.72	0.95	0.49
SMC5	0.38	0.64	0.77	0.54
SMCR1	0.32	0.45	0.44	0.72
SMCR2	0.33	0.48	0.54	0.75
SMCR3	0.42	0.57	0.46	0.86
SMCR4	0.40	0.53	0.50	0.92
SMCR5	0.26	0.36	0.32	0.77
SMCR6	0.39	0.54	0.47	0.90

PP Perceived playfulness, *SM* Social media

To assess the formative construct (social media involvement) it is necessary to validate if each first order construct contributes to form the second order construct (Chin 1998; Hair et al. 2011). Therefore, the weights of the first order constructs on the second order constructs and their significance were examined (see Table 7). For

Table 7 Weights of the first order constructs on the second order constructs

	Dimensions	Weight	t-statistic
Social media involvement	Social media consumption	0.34	67.02***
	Social media creation	0.32	53.51***
	Perceived playfulness social media	0.29	70.49***
	Interest in social media	0.27	40.19***

***Significant at 0.001 level based on 5,000 bootstraps

a formative higher-order construct, the weights of the lower-order constructs are especially important as they represent actionable drivers of the higher-order construct (Becker et al. 2012).

All first order constructs weights are significant, which means that there is empirical support for the first order constructs relevance for the construction of the formative second order construct as theoretically conceived, demonstrating a sufficient level of validity (Hair et al. 2011). Moreover, the weights are higher than 0.10 and their sign is consistent with the underlying theory (Andreev et al. 2009).

In conclusion, the results empirically show that social media involvement can be conceptualized as a formative construct composed by four distinct dimensions, namely interest in social media, social media consumption, social media creation and social media's perceived playfulness.

4 Conclusions, Discussion and Implications

As travel social media applications continue to proliferate a deeper understanding of social media use is needed to advance knowledge and further practice. This research was motivated by a broad interest in understanding travellers' behaviour toward travel related social media, proposing and validating a construct termed social media involvement. This construct is a good start to understand social behaviour to create online social media travel marketing strategies. Depending on their level of involvement, travellers may be more passive or active when they receive advertising communication, and limit or extend their processing of this information (Laurent and Kapferer 1985). Therefore, social media involvement could be a useful instrument for online travel marketer to adapt to these differences. Moreover, travellers that are more involved with social media are considered to be an attractive demographic for online travel marketers (Gretzel et al. 2007). They are more likely to perceive trip planning as an essential process in which they typically become very involved (Gretzel et al. 2007). Online travel marketers can implement strategies to promote the creation of user generated content and enjoyment, in order for travellers to become more involved. For instance, Tripadvisor rewards its members with virtual badges taking into account the number of reviews posted. Moreover, Tripadvisor periodically sends emails to members informing them of how many people read their reviews and which country the review readers are from.

Measuring social media involvement is also important for the personalization of online marketing strategies.

Although there are many studies that focus on social media and their effect on travel planning and travel decisions, there is no empirical evidence linking the use of social media to other constructs. Thus, the social media involvement construct can be incorporated in other models to study possible effects on other aspects regarding travel planning and purchases, such as online travel purchases. It is believed that online social networking will play a crucial role in online transactions (Kasavana et al. 2010). Therefore, future research needs to address the relationship between social media use and online travel purchasing behaviour. Social Media Involvement could perhaps predict such behaviour. This study anticipates that social media involved consumers will be more likely to purchase online than those with lower levels of involvement.

Social media involvement could also be used as a segmentation criterion, followed by a further analysis of the characteristics of each segment, such as age, gender, education level or online travel experience. A deeper understanding of the characteristics of social media users for travel purposes, such as which websites they use and the motives of their interaction will help travel providers assess the revenue opportunities that the various social media channels might provide (Noone et al. 2011). On the other hand, segmentation would allow travel marketers to personalize and cater for travellers with different levels of involvement accordingly. For example, travellers with a high social media involvement level are more likely to create user generated content and can highly influence others. Therefore, travel marketers need to carefully nurture this segment, as they often act as advocates of a brand or an online travel provider.

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